

ing Committee, said at the launch of its Windsor EV that it wants to do away with cars running on fossil fuels. The key: new energy vehicles. "Whether that is a strong hybrid, plug-in hybrid, or battery EV, these will be the cornerstone of JSW MG Motor," said Jindal.

In FY24, sales of its EV portfolio grew by more than 50% over FY23 to 11,681 units.

According to Nomura's Sharma, the JSW-MG Motor JV could pose a challenge to Tata and Mahindra in the mid-range segment, particularly in terms of pricing and speed-to-market.

M&M'S BORN ELECTRIC

M&M, the country's largest SUV manufacturer by volume, has had two failed affairs with EVs. Way back in 2001, it introduced the Reva, which it acquired by buying the manufacturer. The car failed. In 2023, it launched the XUV400 electric, which failed to stand out against its rivals.

Finally, M&M created a subsidiary, Mahindra Electric Automobile Ltd, to handle the EV business. This unit, in which M&M will invest ₹12,000 crore, will launch five EVs by 2026, priced between ₹15 lakh and ₹20 lakh. The company has categorised the electric SUVs as XUV.e8 and XUV.e9 under the XUV brand, and three Born Electric vehicles—BE.05, BE.Rall-E and BE.07—under the INGLO platform. Temasek, the Singapore investment firm, will invest ₹1,200 crore, while British International Investment, the UK's development finance institution, will put in ₹1,200 crore.

Jejurikar says the Born Electric SUVs will be made on the INGLO platform and will have some of the largest battery packs and be built with the latest technology. M&M has also joined hands with Europe's Škoda Volkswagen India to procure EV components from Volkswagen. As Volkswagen struggles to survive in the Indian market, M&M is reportedly picking up a 50% stake at a valuation of \$800 million to \$1 billion. It will invest ₹4,000-5,000 crore in the joint venture, it is believed.

PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES



HERE A TESLA, THERE A TESLA...

Tesla Motors has promised to enter India since 2019 but they are nowhere near to setting up shop

► **Just where is Tesla Motors?** Tesla is to EVs what Xerox was to photocopiers. But Tesla has been doing the Hokey Pokey with India: "You put your left foot in/ You put your left foot out/ ...You do the Hokey Pokey and you turn yourself around!"

Despite a government policy tailor-made for the likes of Tesla, it is nowhere near setting up shop in India.

Cut to 2019, when Co-founder & CEO Elon Musk (in picture above) casually responded to a Twitter user (the US social media company he later took over and rebranded as X) that Tesla would be in India in 2019 or by 2020.

The government decided to roll out the red carpet. The Covid-19 pandemic came and went.

By 2021, Tesla started pushing for a 40% cut in import duties on EVs priced above \$40,000. The government said its existing policy allowed global manufacturers to bring partially built units

and assemble them in India at a lower cost. The government also wanted Tesla to shift its EV manufacturing base from China to India. Musk did not respond.

By December 2021, Tesla got the green signal to launch seven EV models. But it has not launched any so far.

In 2023, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Elon Musk met twice, and Tesla officials even visited India to scout for locations for a factory.

Earlier this year, Musk said he would visit India around April to make some big announcements. That was after the government had launched a new EV policy. But Musk postponed his travel plans, citing heavy commitments.

It is still not known if Tesla Motors will finally set up shop in India. While there is a lot of speculation, what most industry watchers agree on is this: it will not be easy for Tesla in India.

—Astha Oriel